

*Morus bassanus***Northern gannet**

Location N. Atlantic,
Mediterranean

Length 32–35 in
(80–90 cm)

Weight 5½–6½ lb
(2.5–3 kg)

Plumage Sexes similar

Migration Partial migrant

Status Least concern



The northern gannet is a very streamlined seabird, with a torpedo-shaped body, long, narrow wings, and a daggerlike bill, perfectly adapted to plunge-diving for fish. It nests in densely packed colonies, or “gannetries,” on steep cliffs and raised slopes. Highly developed pair-bonding behavior persists throughout the nesting season and, once paired, gannets will remain together for years, returning to the same nest season after season. First breeding occurs between the ages of 3 and 5 years.

NESTING GANNETS

Within their colonies, gannets space their nests at a distance of 2 birds' reach. Gannetries are so densely populated that viewed from afar the high slopes and cliffs can have the appearance of being covered in snow.

BEHAVIORAL PATTERNS

Few seabirds are as sophisticated in their behavioral patterns as the northern gannet. Both its plunge-diving technique and pair-bonding behavior are highly dramatic, while the level of parental care it offers is advanced.

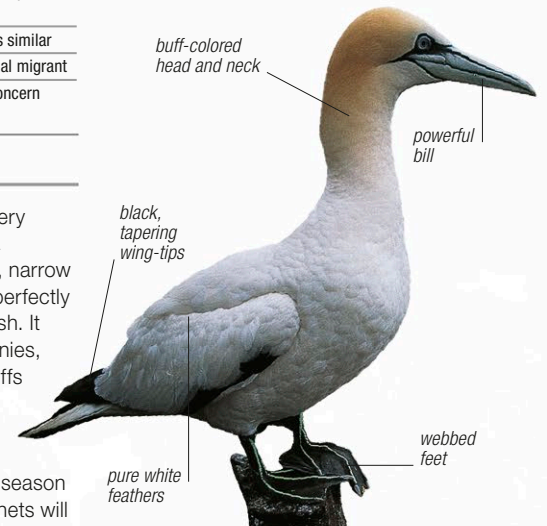
**DRAMATIC PLUNGE-DIVERS**

From up to 150 ft (45 m) above the water, the gannet uses its binocular vision to track fish before plunging at speeds of up to 60 mph (100 kph).

FEEDING A NESTLING

The young gannet reaches deep into its parent's throat to feed on regurgitated fish.

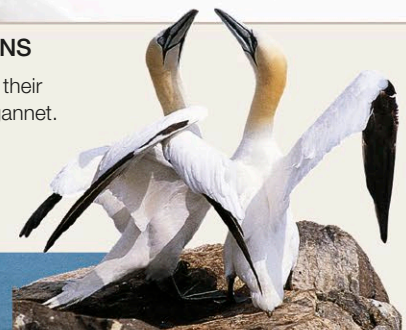
One bluish white egg is laid and then incubated by both parents. Young gannets typically leave the nest around 3 months after hatching and migrate without their parents. Juveniles achieve full adult plumage within 5 years.

**DAZZLING PLUMAGE**

The northern gannet is a very distinctive seabird. Most of its plumage is dazzling white, except for its jet-black wingtips, and the head and back of the neck which have a buff-colored hue, contrasting with its icy blue eyes and bill.

**SHOW OF AGGRESSION**

The northern gannet can be exceptionally aggressive when defending its nest site, using its powerful bill to stab and grip when fighting.

**COURTING COUPLE**

During spectacular bonding displays, partners fence with their bills, as the female aims to allay the male's aggression.

